

According to the Census of Population and Housing - 2024, Nuwara Eliya (8.3%), Batticaloa (6.6%), and Badulla (6.0%) districts respectively reported the highest populations of individuals aged 25 and over who have never attended school. However, in all districts this percentage has declined in 2024 compared to that of 2012. In all districts the largest percentage of population age 25 and over consists of those who have completed Grades 6-10 except Colombo where the highest percentage is G.C.E. (A/L) and over.

A key observation from a comparison with the 2012 Census data is that, by 2024, the proportion of the population aged 25 years and over with educational attainment below the G.C.E. (O/L) level has declined in most districts, except for Nuwara Eliya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi, Batticaloa, and Ampara. Conversely, the proportion of the population with G.C.E. (O/L) and higher levels of education has increased, indicating an overall improvement in the educational attainment of the population.

Language literacy

“Sinhala”, “Tamil” and “English” language literacy

The Census of Population and Housing - 2024 captured language literacy data for the population aged 10 and over. The enumeration captured the ability to speak, read, and write proficiency in three main languages used in Sri Lanka: Sinhala, Tamil, and English and did not account for proficiency in other languages.

Language literacy

Language literacy is defined as the ability of person aged 10 and over to read and write in at least one of the following languages: Sinhala, Tamil, or English. An individual is considered literate in a particular language only if they are capable of reading and writing a short letter or a paragraph with understanding. However, an individual who is only able to read or write their own name, numbers, or a memorized sentence is not considered a literate person.

Language Literacy Rate

The language literacy rate is defined as the total number of individuals aged 10 years or over who reported their ability to read and write at least one of the aforementioned languages as 'Very Good,' 'Good,' or 'Poor' (excluding those categorized as 'unable to read and write'), expressed as a percentage of the total population aged 10 years or over.

Table 7.8 : Language Literacy Rate by Census Year and Sex, 2024

Census year	Language Literacy rate		
	Total	Male	Female
1881	17.4	29.8	3.1
1891	21.7	36.1	5.3
1901	26.4	42.0	8.5
1911	31.0	47.2	12.5
1921	39.9	56.3	21.2
1946	57.8	70.1	43.8
1953	65.4	75.9	53.6
1963	77.1	85.8	67.5
1971	78.5	85.6	70.9
1981	87.2	91.1	83.2
2001	91.1	92.6	89.7
2012	95.7	96.9	94.6
2024	97.4	97.9	97.0